Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour. We are not born with a ready-made list “orange = this”, and yet some meanings repeat surprisingly. They are usually made up of three layers: **the body**, **culture** and **what we have lived through ourselves**.

From the body

Orange is the colour of **the setting sun**, **a fire in the hearth** and **citrus fruit**. The eye reads it as **warm** and **near**. After red it is the second warmest and we **associate** it with what warms and feeds. Juicy fruit, heat, the light at the end of the day. Orange says: **Here is warmth and you may come closer**.

From culture

In one country orange is the colour of football fans and celebrations, in another the colour of **protest** or religious **renunciation**, elsewhere again the colour of a prison uniform or a warning vest. One colour can thus handle both **joy** and **warning**. **What we read in it also depends on where we grew up.** We will look at this in more detail in the section on cultures.

From what you have lived

An orange that **smelled of Christmas at grandmother's**, a children's playroom with orange walls, **the setting sun** on holiday, or the orange vest you had to wear at work. These are associations with **your own signature**. **Two women can look at the same orange** and one feels kindness, the other the pressure to be cheerful again. The colour is the same. **The story is not**.

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is actually “orange” and what is your story about it. You can ask yourself now. **What comes to mind first when I see a woman in an orange dress or a man in an orange shirt?**

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Stories

A colour named after a fruit

In English it is interesting. The word *orange* first named the fruit and only later the colour. The first recorded use as a colour name is from **1502**, in a record of clothing bought for Margaret Tudor. Before that orange was called “yellow-red”; in Old English there was a word for yellow-red and for saffron-yellow, but not for orange as such. The colour thus got its name from the fruit, not the other way round.

The House of Orange and a country that took on a colour

The County of Orange in southern France was raised to a principality in **1163**. Its name is not related to the fruit. In **1544** the principality was inherited by the eleven-year-old **William the Silent** of the House of Nassau, and from the family came what we know today as the House of Orange-Nassau. According to the usual accounts the family adopted the colour orange in the **1570s**, at the time of the Dutch revolt against Spain. William III later became King of England (1689) and the orange-white-blue flag was a forerunner of today's Dutch tricolour. Orange has remained the colour of the country and of the royal family.

Hermès and the orange box

According to a story the company itself tells, Hermès switched to orange boxes in **1942**. During the war there was not enough of its usual packaging and the supplier offered only orange, “the colour nobody wanted”. Hermès chose it rather than leave the goods without packaging. The colour then became its trademark. **The story comes from the company itself and has not been independently verified.** Still, it is a lovely example of how necessity becomes a brand.

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